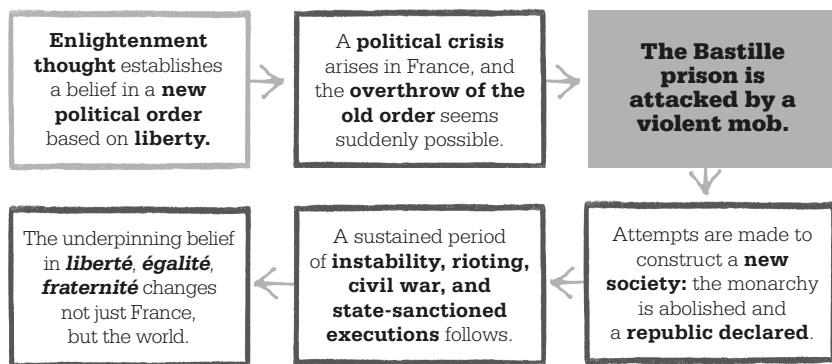




France was effectively bankrupt. In the late 18th century, France's population was expanding rapidly, but unlike England, France had not had an agricultural revolution and remained particularly vulnerable to any failure of the harvest, as happened in 1787 and, again, in 1788. These desperate summers were followed in 1788–1789 by a bitterly harsh winter, leading to mass starvation.

The king's response

The financial crisis critical, Louis was desperate to raise further funds while preserving his authority, so he summoned what was called the States General, a semi-parliamentary body that had last assembled in 1614. It consisted of clergy, the first estate; nobles, the second; and the commons (essentially a kind of bourgeoisie, lawyers predominating), the third. The States General met at Versailles on May 5, 1789. Almost instantly, the nobles and clerics tried to assert that their votes should be worth more than those of the commons. In response, on June 17, the commons declared itself a National Assembly, vesting power in itself instead of the crown. In August, with peasant uprisings across rural France, the Assembly abolished feudal taxes and aristocratic privileges and issued what it called the Declaration of the Rights of Man, a statement asserting fundamental freedoms.

In October 1789, events were suddenly accelerated when a vast crowd, outraged by the lack of bread in Paris, descended on Versailles and forcibly removed the royal

family to Paris, ransacking the palace for good measure. In what would become an unnerving foretaste of the violence to come, the severed heads of the guards at Versailles were paraded on stakes as Louis and his family were escorted to the capital.

It had been comparatively easy to overthrow the existing royal government, but it would prove infinitely harder to establish a new government. It was presumed that a kind of constitutional monarchy would be the most obvious solution. In the end, France found itself wrenched between those arguing for this more or less moderate option, and those in favor of a much more radical republican alternative.

The First Republic

Although in most important respects Louis's reign seemed by now to be doomed, the king had not entirely abandoned hope of reasserting his authority. Large numbers of French aristocrats—émigrés—had already fled France, fearing the revolution had made it unsafe. In trying to persuade other European regimes—Austria above all, whose emperor was the brother of the French queen Marie-Antoinette—they stirred up opposition to the revolution, but their principal impact was to reinforce a determination in France to see the revolution succeed.

In June 1791, Louis attempted to escape, but was intercepted near the border with the Low Countries and brought back to Paris to the jeers of the »